

FACT SHEET: LYME DISEASE

May 2025

WHAT IS LYME DISEASE?

Lyme disease is a bacterial infection transmitted by the bite of a blacklegged tick. Lyme disease may cause symptoms affecting the skin, nervous system and/or the joints. Not all ticks are infected with the bacteria that cause Lyme disease.

WHO CAN GET LYME DISEASE?

Anyone can get Lyme disease. People who spend time outside where infected ticks are common, such as grassy or wooded locations, are at an increased risk of exposure. Most infections occur during late spring and summer, with a peak in June and July, but may occur throughout the year.

WHAT ARE THE SYMPTOMS OF LYME DISEASE?

The symptoms of Lyme disease include:

- A red, slowly expanding “bull’s eye” rash
- Tiredness
- Fever
- Stiff neck
- Muscle aches
- Joint pain

If left untreated, weeks to months later some people may develop fever, rash, facial paralysis, an irregular heartbeat, and arthritis.

HOW IS LYME DISEASE SPREAD?

Lyme disease is spread through the bite of an infected blacklegged tick. The tick does not usually infect the individual until it has been attached for 24 to 36 hours. Therefore, it is important to check your skin daily for ticks.

IS A PERSON WITH LYME DISEASE CONTAGIOUS?

No, the disease is not spread from person to person.

HOW IS LYME DISEASE TREATED AND IS THERE A VACCINE?

There are several antibiotics available for the treatment of Lyme disease. The length of treatment depends on symptoms, age, allergies and if the patient is pregnant or not. The CDC generally advises against using antibiotics to prevent tick-borne infections following tick bites. On the other hand, in some cases, a single dosage of doxycycline administered following a tick bite in a region where Lyme disease is prevalent may reduce the risk of contracting the illness.

CAN LYME DISEASE BE PREVENTED?

Lyme disease can be prevented by reducing exposure to ticks. Some ways that this can be done include:

- Using EPA-registered tick repellents when walking through areas that may contain ticks.
- Wearing light-colored socks, long pants, and long-sleeved shirts. Tuck pants into socks.
- Conducting a full-body check for ticks with a mirror after spending time outdoors and removing attached ticks from your body, clothing, and pets quickly with fine-tipped tweezers. Following removal, clean the bite area with soap and water.

WANT MORE INFORMATION?

Information about Lyme disease and other related health topics can be found at [cdc.gov](https://www.cdc.gov). The DC Department of Health promotes the health and safety of the District residents. For additional information, please visit dchealth.dc.gov or call (202) 442-5865.